

CHESS MASTERY LIBRARY | FIRST EDITION

Tactical Patterns

See the geometry before calculating it

THE PROMISE

Build a compact pattern vocabulary and connect every pattern to a visible trigger.

VOLUME 03 OF 15

READ | RECALL | DECIDE | RETEST

What this volume should change

- Recognize tactical triggers such as loose pieces, aligned pieces, and weak back ranks.
- Combine motifs instead of searching for isolated tricks.
- Verify patterns with calculation rather than trusting recognition alone.

HOW TO STUDY

Read one section. Close the PDF and state its decision rule from memory. Solve the position lab before viewing the answer. Revisit the lab after two days and again after one week.

Inside this volume

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This volume is an original teaching synthesis of established chess ideas. Positions marked illustrative are designed to isolate a decision, not to replace full-game analysis. Board diagrams use Colin M. L. Burnett's Cburnett piece artwork from Lichess, licensed GPLv2+.

Tactics begin with unstable features

A tactic is usually enabled before it is executed. One piece becomes loose, two valuable pieces become aligned, a defender is overloaded, or the king loses flight squares. Train your eyes to notice these preconditions on every move.

Position cues

- Loose pieces: undefended or defended only once.
- Alignment: king and queen, queen and rook, or two rooks on one line.
- Restricted king: few legal squares, blocked pawns, or a weak back rank.
- Overworked defender: one piece must perform two incompatible jobs.
- Forcing access: a check, capture, or threat gains time to exploit the defect.

PRACTICE RULE

After the opponent moves, scan CCT plus LPDO: checks, captures, threats, and loose pieces drop off. Name the trigger before calculating.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Pattern labels are search aids, not proof. A familiar fork square may be poisoned or tactically unavailable.

Forks and double attacks

A double attack creates two problems with one move. Knights and pawns are famous for forks, but queens, rooks, bishops, and even kings can attack two targets. The deeper skill is identifying two targets before searching for the move.

Position cues

- Look for an exposed king plus an undefended high-value piece.
- Consider forcing one target onto a vulnerable square first.
- A discovered attack can create the second threat while revealing the first.
- Check whether the forking piece can be captured with tempo.

PRACTICE RULE

In puzzles, first circle the two desired targets. Then find squares from which one piece can reach both.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not count a fork as winning until you calculate captures, counterchecks, and whether one target can move with tempo.

Pins, skewers, and line clearance

Line tactics use geometry. In a pin, the front piece cannot move safely because something more valuable stands behind it. In a skewer, the valuable front piece moves and exposes the rear piece. Clearance removes an obstruction from a file, rank, or diagonal.

Position cues

- Absolute pin: moving the piece would expose the king and is illegal.
- Relative pin: moving is legal but loses material or position.
- Cross-pin: a piece is constrained along two lines.
- X-ray: a line piece attacks through an intervening piece.

PRACTICE RULE

Trace every rook, bishop, and queen ray to its first obstruction. Ask what happens if that obstruction moves or is exchanged.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

A pinned piece may still defend a square, depending on the piece and king geometry. Do not erase it mentally without checking legality.

Remove, deflect, or overload the defender

Many combinations work because a key defender is doing too much. Capturing it is only one method. You may deflect it from its duty, lure it to a bad square, interfere with its line, or force it to choose between two tasks.

Position cues

- Removal: exchange or sacrifice for the defender.
- Deflection: force the defender away with a threat.
- Decoy: lure a piece onto a tactically vulnerable square.
- Interference: insert a piece between defender and target.
- Overload: create two threats the defender cannot meet together.

PRACTICE RULE

When an attack almost works, ask which defender prevents it. Search for a forcing way to change that defender's job.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Sacrificing for a defender is sound only if the follow-up is concrete. 'The king looks weak' is not a calculation.

Discovered attacks and intermediate moves

A discovered attack moves one piece to reveal another piece's line. An intermediate move interrupts an expected sequence with a stronger forcing move. Both punish automatic recaptures and shallow move-order assumptions.

Position cues

- When pieces face each other through one blocker, inspect every move of the blocker.
- Before recapturing, look for checks and attacks on a more valuable piece.
- Zwischenzug candidates often appear after a seemingly forced exchange.
- Discovered checks are especially forcing because the moving piece can create a second threat.

PRACTICE RULE

Every time you expect a recapture, pause and scan all checks. This single habit finds many practical tactics.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

An intermediate move fails if the opponent has an even stronger in-between move. Continue the forcing sequence until it settles.

Mating nets and escape-square control

Mate is not produced by checks alone. It is produced by controlling the king's possible squares while preventing blocks and captures. Quiet moves often finish a net more efficiently than another check.

Position cues

- Map the king's legal squares before selecting a check.
- Count defenders of the checking square.
- Look for back-rank confinement and pawn-shield self-blocking.
- Consider a quiet move that removes the last flight square or adds an attacker.

PRACTICE RULE

In mating puzzles, list all legal defenses after each check: capture, block, or king move. If one category is impossible, say why.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

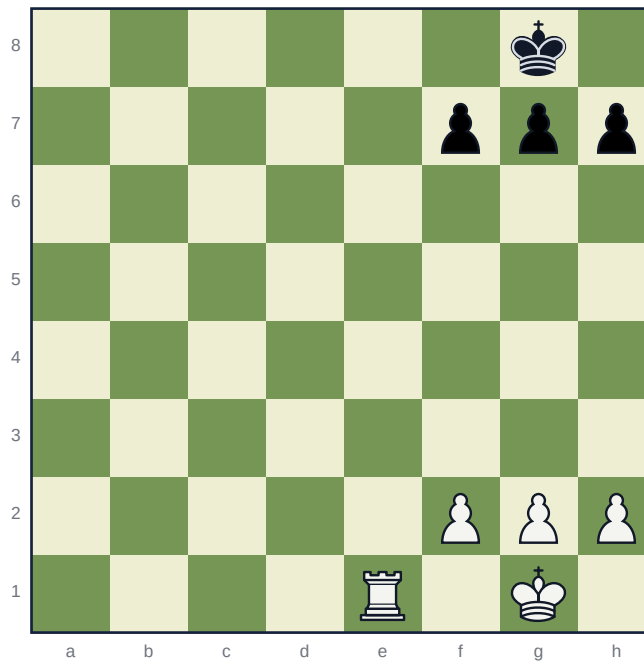
Do not assume the opponent must accept a sacrifice. Include declines and counterchecks.

Position Lab

Do not turn the page until you have written a candidate list or explanation. Score the process separately from whether your final answer is correct.

LAB 01

White to move. Identify the mating trigger before choosing the move.

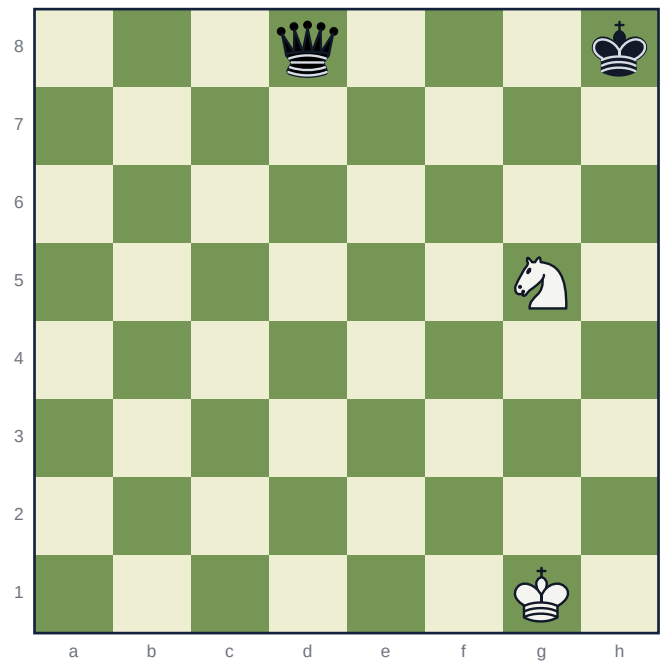


BEFORE CHECKING

Name the cue, list at least two candidates or explanations, and test the strongest objection.

LAB 02

White to move. Find the two targets before finding the move.



Knight fork geometry

BEFORE CHECKING

Name the cue, list at least two candidates or explanations, and test the strongest objection.

Position Lab - Answers

LAB 01

The black king is sealed by its own pawns and has no flight square. Re8 is checkmate: the rook attacks along the eighth rank, the king cannot move to f8 or h8, and its own pawns occupy f7, g7, and h7.

LAB 02

The targets are the king on h8 and queen on d8. Nf7+ attacks both. After the king responds, White captures the queen. The check gives the knight the tempo required for the fork.

Daily Study Card

Use this as a compact recall sheet. Say each item without looking, then open the volume only for the item you cannot explain.

- Scan checks, captures, threats, and loose pieces.
- Name the unstable feature.
- Find two targets or one overloaded defender.
- Calculate captures, blocks, king moves, and counterchecks.
- Record the trigger, not only the winning move.

TRANSFER TEST

During your next five serious games, mark every position where this volume's cue appeared. Improvement means you noticed the cue and used a better process, even when the game result was noisy.

CONTINUE WITH

02_Calculation_Method.pdf

Personal notes
